Zitian Wang

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Education

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics, University of Virginia — 2021 – 2027 (expected)

Dissertation: "Auction for Prominence and Price-Directed Consumer Search: Theory and Experiment"

Committee: Charles Holt, Po-Hsuan Lin, Peter Troyan, Noah Myung

M.A. in Economics, Columbia University — 2019 – 2020

B.A. in Economics and B.S. in Financial Mathematics, University of California, Los Angeles — 2015 – 2019

Research Fields

Experimental Economics, Behavioral Economics, Game Theory, Industrial Organization

Job Market Paper

1. **Wang, Z.** (2026) "Auction for Prominence and Price-Directed Consumer Search: Theory and Experiment"

Working Papers

2. **Wang, Z.**, Ahmed, I., Unjitwattana, P., Xie, E.Y., Fong, M.-J. & Lin, P.-H. (2026) "Revisiting the Intra-Team Communication Method to Elicit Level-k Reasoning in Beauty Contests and 11–20 Games" **(First author)**. Revising at **European Economic Review**.
3. **Wang, Z.** (2025) "Coordination under Uncertainty and Noisy Communication: A Generalized Email Game" [Slides]

Conference, Seminar and Workshop Presentations

2026	Economic Science Association (ESA) North American Meeting*, ESA World Meeting, Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting*, BEEMA10*, Conference on Field Experiments in Strategy*, UVA Theory/Experimental Student Workshop
2025	Economic Science Association North American Meeting, BEEMA9

(* scheduled)

Grants and Awards

Director of Graduate Studies Research Grant (US$2,000), University of Virginia	2026
Graduate School of Arts & Sciences Council Grant (US$500), University of Virginia	2026
Travel Grant, Conference on Field Experiments in Strategy (US$400), Duke University	2026

Professional Activities

Organizer

UVA Theory/Experimental Economics Student Workshop 2025 – Present
UVA Theory/Experimental Economics Reading Group 2025 – Present

Research Experience

Research assistant for Prof. Peter Troyan, University of Virginia 2026
Research assistant for Prof. Denis Nekipelov, University of Virginia 2023

Summer School Attendance

Northwestern–Kellogg Summer School in Economic Theory, Northwestern University 2026
Behavioral Game Theory Summer School, University of East Anglia 2026
Chicago School in Experimental Economics, University of Chicago 2024

Teaching

Instructor, University of Virginia

Intermediate Macroeconomics (evaluation: 4.6/5) Fall 2025, Spring 2026

Teaching Assistant, University of Virginia

Principles of Microeconomics Fall 2022
Principles of Macroeconomics Spring 2023
Intermediate Macroeconomics Fall 2023
Intermediate Microeconomics Spring 2024
Global Financial Markets Fall 2024, Fall 2025
Economics of Risk, Uncertainty, and Information Spring 2025

Teaching Assistant, Columbia University

Principles of Economics Summer 2020

Skills

Programming: Python, oTree, Stata, MATLAB, LaTeX, HTML, CSS, JavaScript
Languages: Chinese (native), English (near-native)
Certificate: CFA Level I

References

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Abstracts

1. Auction for Prominence and Price-Directed Consumer Search: Theory and Experiment

On digital marketplaces, consumer search is costly, so sellers compete to be shown first. We develop a model of search prominence and test it in a laboratory experiment that varies the search friction. Two sellers bid in a second-price auction for a prominent position that gives the winner a search-cost advantage over its rival. Both sellers then post prices simultaneously. Observing both prices and the prominent seller's match value for free, the consumer decides whether to pay a sunk cost to search the non-prominent seller before buying, or to leave. The experiment confirms the theory's central prediction: the prominent seller prices higher than its rival, and this gap widens as prominence grows, indicating that prominence confers market power in pricing. But behavior departs from theory in several ways. Prices are more dispersed than predicted, compressing the price gap and reshaping how consumers search. Under strong prominence, this price-induced search keeps consumers loyal to the prominent seller and lifts its profit above the competitive benchmark. Under weak prominence, sellers overbid so severely for the position that their profits fall below it. Consumers deviate from optimal search in both directions while staying close to optimal on average, and capture more surplus than theory predicts. These welfare anomalies stem mainly from the distorted prices that prominence induces, rather than from noisy consumer search alone.

2. Revisiting the Intra-Team Communication Method to Elicit Level-k Reasoning in Beauty Contests and 11–20 Games

We provide the first replication of the original beauty contest experiment with the intra-team communication method of Burchardi and Penczynski (2014). We also apply this method to the 11–20 game, another canonical setting for studying level-k reasoning proposed by Arad and Rubinstein (2012). Focusing on the "re-ordered" version introduced by Goeree et al. (2018), which exhibits heterogeneous noisy behavior not well explained by the standard level-k model, we not only provide the first replication of this re-ordered 11–20 game, but also use the method to illuminate the reasoning underlying such behavior and its relationship to level-k thinking. Overall, our study offers an integrated perspective on empirical patterns in two canonical games with boundedly rational behavior.

3. Coordination under Uncertainty and Noisy Communication: A Generalized Email Game

Which information transmission protocols improve coordination under uncertainty and noisy communication? Theory is indeterminate between an inefficient "tacit" equilibrium, where information is ignored, and an efficient "vocal" equilibrium, where players act on it. We test this in a laboratory experiment based on a generalized email game, exogenously varying the message-generation rule across three protocols. Vocal behavior rises with the incentive to take the risky action, and relative to an automatic protocol, voluntary messaging significantly improves coordination. However, a sunk cost to sending reduces vocality by inducing senders to opt out. These patterns suggest that voluntariness credibly signals players' intent to coordinate via forward induction, and that the value of cost-free signaling for equilibrium selection hinges on the alignment of interests.